

**County Administration Workshop: August 11, 2026
1:30 p.m. - Board of Commissioners Conference Room**

Attending: Commissioners Ron A. Smith; Colene M. Martin; Gary L. Richardson; and Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:30 p.m.

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

2. Department Business

Due to a scheduling conflict, the Board considered Human Resources Item 2.d.1.a. first.

d. Human Resources (taken first)

1. Position Requisitions

a. Community Corrections - Replace one Senior Department Specialist position with a Community Corrections Case Specialist position

Natalie Eckhardt-Doupe, Interim Human Resources Director, and Scott Hyde, Community Justice Director, presented the request to replace one existing Senior Department Specialist position in Community Corrections with a Community Corrections Case Specialist position.

Mr. Hyde reported that the number of individuals on community supervision had increased from approximately 750 at the beginning of the year to approximately 820, with additional growth anticipated as lower-level drug cases are prosecuted. The reclassified position would assist with increased intake volume, lower-risk client check-ins, compliance monitoring, and required data tracking. He stated that sufficient funding is available within the Adult Community Corrections Fund to support the staffing change.

The Board approved the position reclassification without objection.

a. Public Health

1. WIC Synergy Contract Amendment

Janet Fredrickson, Public Health Director, and Kaitlen Carbajal presented an amendment extending the County's contract with Synergy for qualified WIC nutrition services through the end of 2026.

Public Health explained that WIC requires access to qualified nutrition services and that Synergy has been used as a temporary solution since the County lost its in-house dietitian. The amendment adds approximately \$30,000, paid from the WIC budget. Synergy currently provides approximately 40 to 50 hours of service per month at about \$70 per hour. Staff hopes to have an in-house dietitian in place by January 2027; that position would be partially assigned to WIC and could also support broader clinic nutrition services under a recently received grant.

Commissioner Martin moved to approve the WIC Synergy Contract Amendment as presented. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

b. Transit

1. EV Battery Work Order

Scott Chancey, Transit Director, presented a work order for battery repairs to the County's remaining 2019 battery-electric transit bus.

Mr. Chancey explained that, following a 2024 thermal event involving another electric bus, additional safety systems were installed before the 2019 bus could be returned to service. A manufacturer battery evaluation found that six of the twelve battery packs should be refurbished or replaced. The proposed work is approximately \$30,000 to \$31,000, with about 89.75 percent paid from an existing federal grant and an estimated local match of approximately \$3,100 already available in the Transit budget. Staff expects the repair to restore a usable, though limited, driving range for partial shifts and backup service. Mr. Chancey recommended the partial battery repair rather than an approximately \$70,000 full replacement because of uncertainty regarding battery longevity and range, and because remaining grant funds may be rolled into a future bus-replacement grant.

The Board approved the EV battery work order without objection.

c. Finance**1. Economic Development Committee****a. Board Order approving Membership**

Matthew Eide, Finance Director, updated the Board on recruitment for the Economic Development Committee and the membership requirements contained in the Board Order.

Finance has received approximately a dozen applications following additional public outreach, but has had difficulty finding applicants who meet the designated large-business and medium-business categories. The Board and staff also discussed the intended meaning of the employment-readiness position, with Workforce Oregon, schools, and Rogue Community College identified as possible sources. Mr. Eide stated that Finance will continue targeted outreach and may return with recommended changes to the membership requirements if the required categories cannot be filled. The Board discussed whether a seven-member committee may be unnecessarily difficult to recruit and convene, and agreed the structure can be reevaluated after the first year.

b. Governing Rules

Mr. Eide also discussed the proposed governing rules, timeline, and intended use of economic-development lottery funds. The Board emphasized that the funds should produce tangible economic benefit for Josephine County, particularly job creation and infrastructure that supports economic activity, rather than primarily funding studies. State requirements for the lottery funds were described as broad, allowing the County to develop more specific local priorities. Because of recruitment delays, the committee process may extend into November, with a goal of completing the current cycle before year-end and bringing recommendations to the Board early next year for the following fiscal year. Mr. Eide will return with proposed membership and rule adjustments as needed.

3. Board Business**a. Association of O&C Counties (AOCC) Dues**

The Board discussed whether Josephine County should rejoin the Association of O&C Counties (AOCC) and the value of the Association's federal advocacy, legal and policy work, and access to information regarding O&C lands and federal timber revenue.

Commissioners discussed the County's dependence on federally controlled lands and the importance of coordinated advocacy in Washington, D.C. Commissioner Richardson requested additional financial information before committing to membership, including the Association's budget and expenditures. Because AOCC dues were not included in the adopted County budget, the Board also discussed whether dues could be phased in, prorated, or paid in installments rather than as one annual payment.

The Board directed Chair Smith to follow up with Doug Roberts of the Association of O&C Counties and with Legal Counsel Wally Hicks regarding AOCC budget information and options for a phased or installment payment of membership dues. No formal action was taken on membership.

b. COCONUT - Automation Opportunity Sweep

Tracy Thompson presented a proposal titled COCONUT - Automation Opportunity Sweep, describing it as a government-efficiency assessment in which automation and artificial intelligence could be used as tools to identify process improvements.

Mr. Thompson proposed assessing one to three County departments by interviewing staff, reviewing workflows and standard operating procedures, identifying performance measures and bottlenecks, and developing recommendations for measurable efficiencies. He stated that the assessment was not intended to reduce County staffing, but to reduce repetitive work and allow existing employees to focus on higher-value tasks. He described two possible pricing approaches: an approximately \$10,000 up-front assessment for up to three departments, or an assessment performed at his own expense with an executive summary provided to the County and a \$15,000 charge only if the Board chose to purchase the detailed findings and implementation roadmap.

The Board questioned how County data, systems, intellectual property, confidentiality, and long-term ownership would be handled; how the proposed assessment would interact with existing departmental software; what staff time would be required; and what comparable work Mr. Thompson had previously completed. Mr. Thompson stated that County data and systems would remain County property, while his underlying methodologies would remain proprietary. He acknowledged that he had not previously implemented this exact system in an organization comparable in size and structure to Josephine County, although he cited his prior scientific, business, and process-optimization experience.

Information Technology staff advised that the County is already evaluating departmental processes and testing automation and AI-related tools, and expressed uncertainty about whether an outside assessment is presently necessary. The County Assessor also discussed existing workflow performance, the importance of involving employees, and whether a competitive procurement process may ultimately be appropriate. The Board expressed interest in efficiency improvements but also concern about employee perceptions, risk, security, and moving too quickly with emerging technology.

The Board requested that the proposal and supporting materials be reviewed by Legal Counsel and Information Technology before further consideration. No formal action was taken, and the matter may return for additional discussion after that review.

4. Other (ORS 192.640(1) - Commissioners may introduce other matters for consideration by the entire Board)

No additional matters were taken up.

5. Additional Subject Matters from Commissioners/Announcements

Commissioner Martin reminded the public that the Board would hold an evening Weekly Business Session the following day at 5:30 p.m. and would continue discussion of the Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention levy. She encouraged members of the public to attend and provide input.

The meeting adjourned at 3:01 p.m.